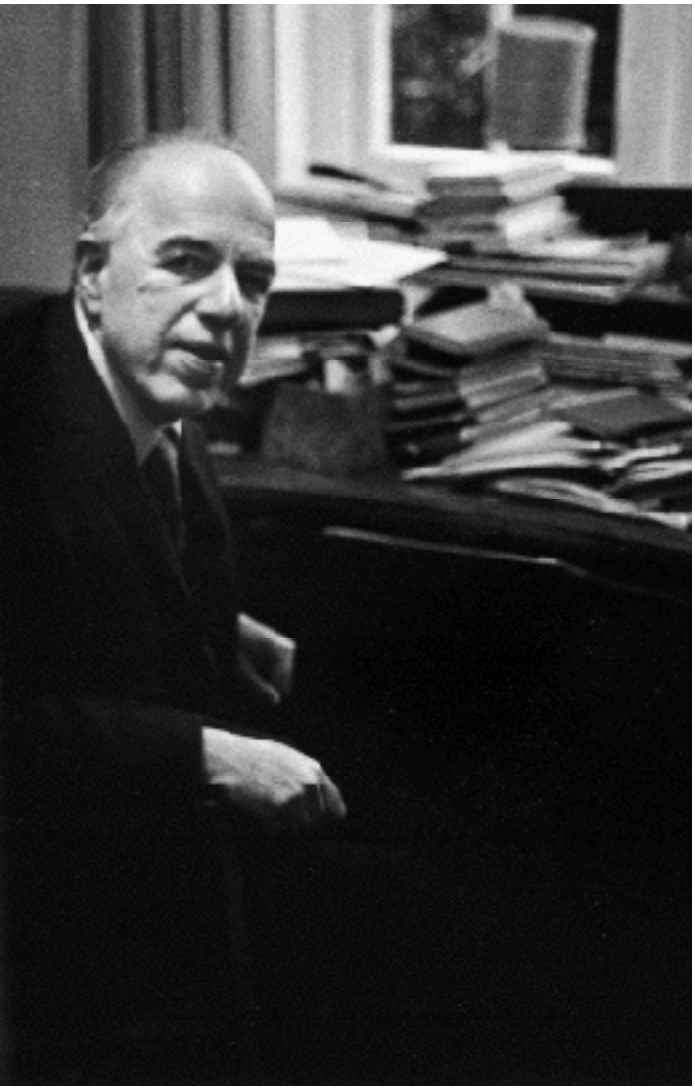
E.H. Gombrich

THE STORY OF ART

PHAIDON



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Art for Eternity

Egypt, Mesopotamia, Crete

Some form of art exists everywhere on the globe, but the story of art as a continuous effort does not begin in the caves of southern France or among the North American Indians. There is no direct tradition which links these strange beginnings with our own days, but there is a direct tradition, handed down from master to pupil, and from pupil to admirer or copyist, which links the art of our own days, any house or any poster, with the art of the Nile Valley of some five thousand years ago. For we shall see that the Greek masters went to school with the Egyptians, and we are all the pupils of the Greeks. Thus the art of Egypt has a tremendous importance for us.

Everyone knows that Egypt is the land of the pyramids, *figure 31*, those mountains of stone which stand like weathered landmarks on the distant horizon of history. However remote and mysterious they seem, they tell us much of their own story. They tell us of a land which was so thoroughly organized that it was possible to pile up these gigantic mounds in the lifetime of a single king, and they tell us of kings who were so rich and powerful that they could force thousands and thousands of workers or slaves to toil for them year in, year out, to quarry the stones, to drag them to the building site, and to shift them with the most primitive means till the tomb was ready to receive the king. No king and no people would have gone to such expense, and taken so much trouble, for the creation of a mere monument. In fact, we know that the pyramids had their practical importance in the eyes of the kings and their subjects. The king was considered a divine being who held sway over them, and on his departure from this earth he would again ascend to the gods whence he had come. The pyramids soaring up to the sky would probably help him to make his ascent. In any case they would preserve his sacred body from decay. For the



1

Peter Paul Rubens
Portrait of his son Nicholas,
c.1620



2

Albrecht Dürer
Portrait of his mother, 1514



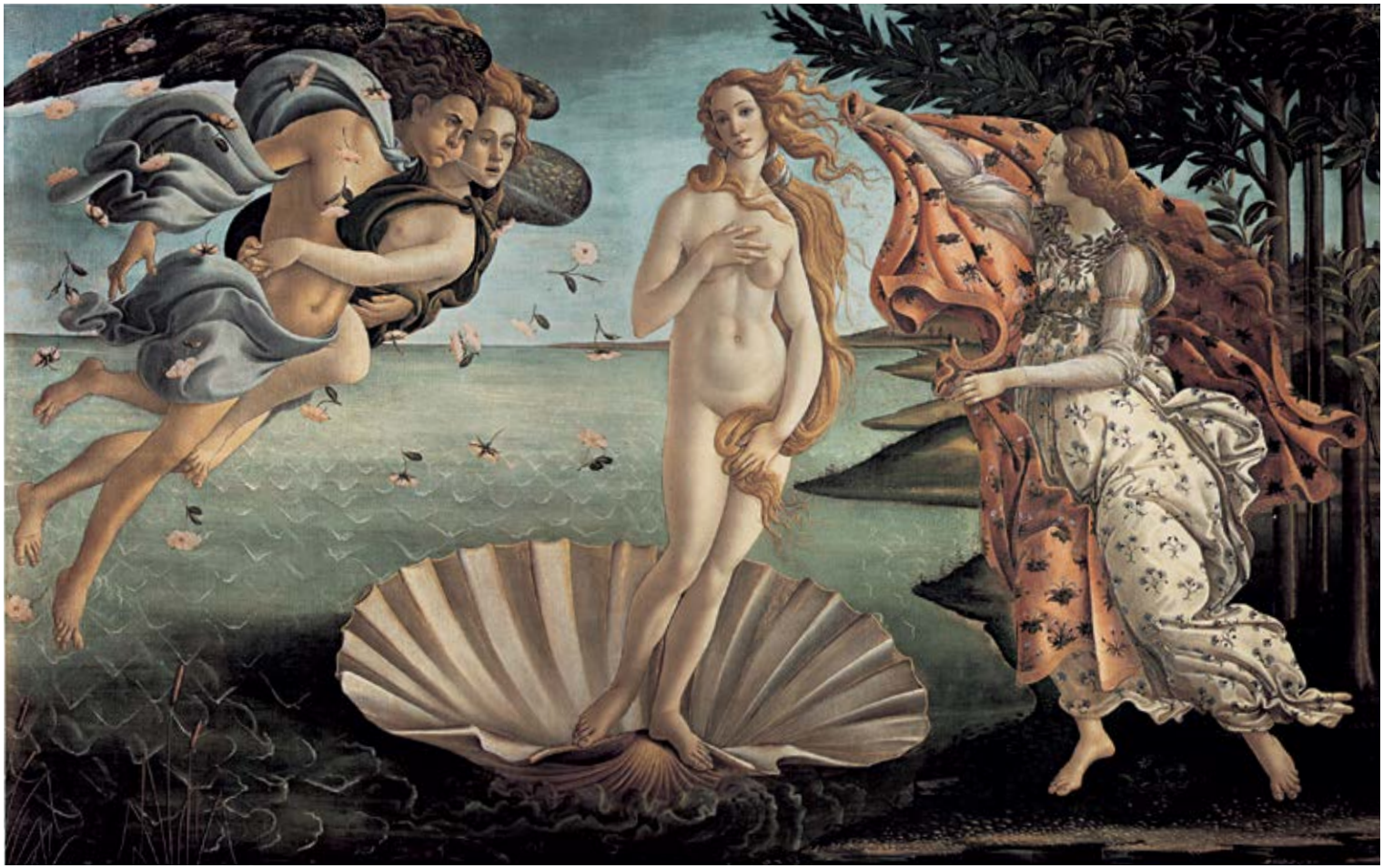
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Praxiteles
Hermes with the young Dionysus,
*c.*340 BC



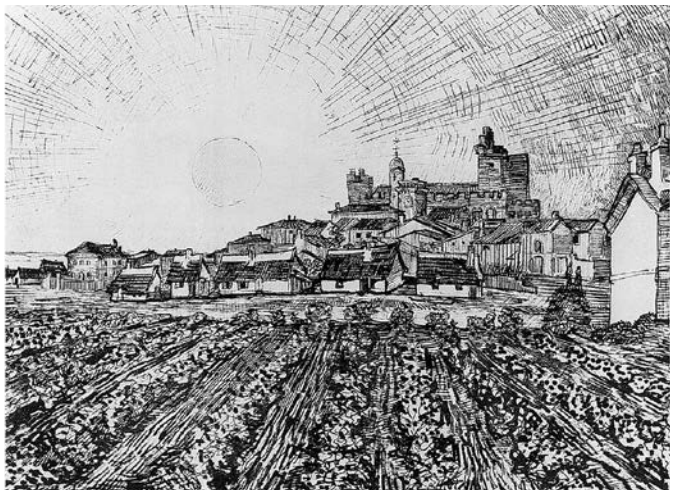
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Detail of figure 62



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Sandro Botticelli
The birth of Venus, c.1485



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Vincent van Gogh
View of Les Saintes-Maries-de-la-Mer, 1888



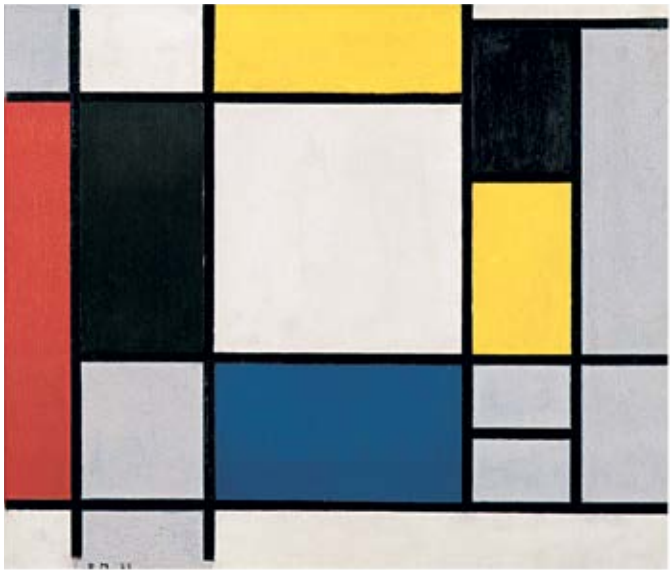
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Vincent van Gogh
The artist's room in Arles, 1889



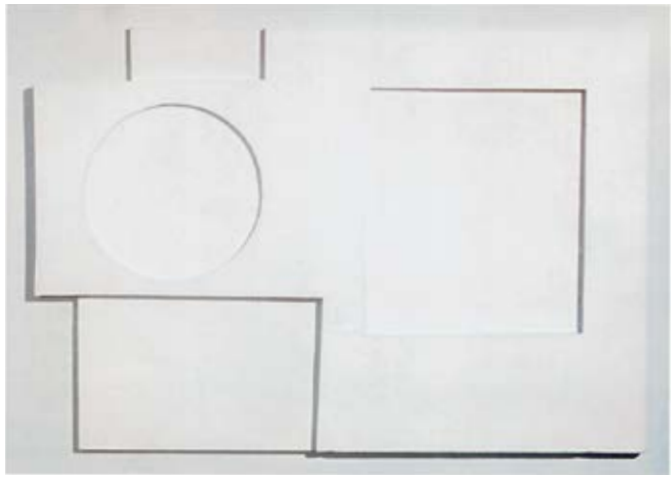
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Paul Gauguin
Te Rerioa (Day-dreaming), 1897



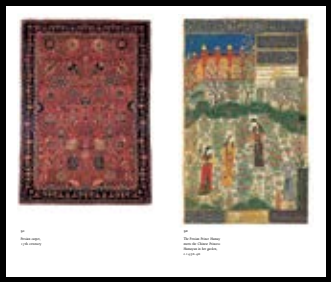
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Piet Mondrian
Composition with red, black, blue, yellow and grey, 1920



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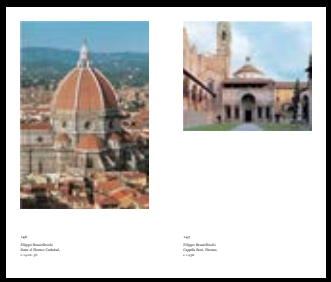
Ben Nicholson
1934 (relief), 1934













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1064 pp
120 col illus.
ISBN: 978 1 83866 658 3

Phaidon Press Limited
2 Cooperage Yard
Stratford
London E15 2UR

Phaidon Press Inc.
65 Bleecker Street
New York, NY 10012

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phaidon.com

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